

Cessationism

prc-cessationism

Spiritual Gifts · Sign Gifts · doctrine · divided_lineages

DISPUTED

breadth broad
directness direct
variants stable

Statement under examination

The miraculous sign gifts (apostleship, prophecy, tongues, miraculous healings) ceased with the apostolic age and the closing of the canon.

In plain language

The proposition says the miraculous sign gifts ended with the apostolic age and the closing of the canon (the closing of the list of inspired books). The key passage is 1 Corinthians 13:8-10. There prophecy and knowledge are said to be abolished using the verb meaning to render inoperative or abolish (katargeo) in the future passive (a future action done to the subject), while tongues will cease using a different verb, the verb meaning to cease (pauo), in the future middle (a future action where the subject acts on its own). The trigger for the abolishing is the coming of the complete or perfect thing (to teleion). The single Greek word meaning complete or perfect (teleios) does not by itself say what the complete thing is. Across the New Testament it can mean mature persons, or morally complete states, or a finished or whole thing. The text gives a time clause, whenever it comes (hotan elthe), but does not name a date. So the words allow a reading where the complete thing is the finished body of revelation, and they also allow a reading where it is the final state described in the very next verse as seeing face to face (prosopon pros prosopon), knowing fully as one is fully known. That next verse, with now (arti) versus then (tote) and face to face vocabulary, is the strongest single reason readers diverge. Ephesians 2:20 places apostles and prophets in a foundation image (themelios, foundation) with Christ as cornerstone (akrogoniaios), which fits an argument that the foundation is laid once and not repeated. Hebrews 1:1-2 contrasts God speaking long ago in the prophets with speaking in the Son in these last days, and Hebrews 2:3-4 describes signs (semeia) and wonders (terata) as past confirmation of the message that was heard from the Lord. Second Corinthians 12:12 calls the cluster of signs, wonders, and powers (semeia, terata, dynamis) the signs of the apostle (ta semeia tou apostolou). These verses lean toward a confirming and foundational function, but none states an end date for the gifts in plain words. Working in the other direction, 1 Corinthians 12:7-11 lists prophecy, tongues, and miracles as Spirit-given operations distributed as he wills (kathos bouletai), and chapters 14 and 1 Thessalonians 5 give standing rules for using and testing these gifts with no expiry clause attached. Acts 2:17 reads Peter as quoting Joel of the last days (en tais eschatais hemeraiis), naming the whole church age as the period of Spirit-given prophesying. Because the central word leaves its referent open and the surrounding texts pull in more than one direction, the word-level data sustains competing readings and does not settle the timing. The honest word-level verdict is therefore disputed rather than a clear yes or no.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0652	ἀπόστολος	apostolos	apostle	79
G0737	ἄρτι	arti	now	37
G1100	γλῶσσα	glossa	tongue	50

G1108	γνώσις	gnosis	knowledge	29
G1411	δύναμις	dynamis	power	120
G2310	θεμέλιος	themelios	foundation	16
G2673	καταργέω	katargeo	to abate	27
G2980	λαλέω	laleō	to speak	
G3313	μέρος	meros	part	42
G3973	παύω	pauo	to cease	15
G4383	πρόσωπον	prosopon	face	77
G4394	προφητεία	propheteia	prophecy	19
G4396	προφήτης	prophetes	prophet	149
G4592	σημεῖον	semeion	sign	77
G5046	τέλειος	teleios	perfect	19
G5059	τέρας	teras	wonders	16
G5119	τότε	tote	then	162

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

The word-level pattern at 1 Corinthians 13:8-10 is genuinely contested. Prophecy and knowledge take the future passive form of the verb meaning to be rendered inoperative or abolished (katargeo, G2673, will be rendered inoperative); tongues take the future middle form of a different verb meaning to cease (pauo, G3973, will cease); and the trigger for the abolishing verbs is the arrival of the complete or perfect thing (to teleion, G5046, neuter singular). The Greek does not, at the level of vocabulary, fix what the complete or perfect thing (to teleion) refers to. The temporal clause meaning whenever it comes (hotan elthe) leaves the date open, and the immediate context (verse 12) glosses the contrast with now (arti, G0737) seeing through a mirror in a riddle (di esoptrou en ainigmati) versus then (tote, G5119) face to face (prosopon pros prosopon, G4383), which at the word level tilts the referent toward end-of-age seeing rather than the closing of the Bible. On the other hand, Ephesians 2:20 places apostles and prophets in the foundation (themelios, G2310) of the household with Christ as the cornerstone (akrogoniaios), and Hebrews 1:1-2 and 2:3-4 cast the prophetic and sign-and-wonder vocabulary in a past-confirming frame (the salvation was confirmed, ebebaiothe; God co-witnessed, synepimartyrountos). 2 Corinthians 12:12 ties the signs of the apostle (ta semeia tou apostolou, G4592 + G0652) specifically to apostolic identity. These three vectors at the word level support a foundational reading. Neither vector dates the gifts in plain words, and the present-tense, ongoing simple-statement-of-fact gift catalog of 1 Corinthians 12:7-11 plus the standing regulatory commands of 1 Corinthians 14 and 1 Thessalonians 5:19-21 carry no expiry clause. The lexical store (the word-level data) sustains both readings without adjudicating between them, which is the textual reason this verdict lands at disputed.

Scripture

1Cor.13.8 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2673 καταργέω, G3973 παύω, G4394 προφητεία, G1100 γλώσσα, G1108 γνώσις

Force. Three distinct cessation verbs are deployed in one verse. Prophecies and knowledge are governed by the future passive of the verb meaning to abolish or render inoperative (katargeo, G2673, will be rendered inoperative or abolished, katargethesontai); tongues take the future middle form of a different verb meaning to cease (pauo, G3973, will cease, pausontai). The voice contrast between the passive of katargeo (G2673, to abolish, passive meaning the action is done to the subject) and the middle of pauo (G3973, to cease, middle meaning the subject is acting on its own) is a real word-level datum, pressed by some as evidence that tongues cease of their own accord prior to the other two gifts, and by others as a parallel way of saying the same thing about the temporary nature of present partial gifts under love. The verbs alone do not date the cessation; that is set by the dependent temporal clause (an 'if-then' or 'whenever' clause) introduced in verse 10.

1Cor.13.9 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3313 μέρος, G4394 προφητεία, G1108 γνώσις

Force. Present knowing and prophesying are qualified as in part or partial (ek merous, G3313, in part, partial). The partiality is set in explicit contrast to the complete or perfect (to teleion) in the next verse, framing the present gifts as provisional. The word meaning part (meros, G3313) marks incompleteness but does not by itself date the terminus (the end-point).

1Cor.13.10 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5046 τέλειος, G3313 μέρος, G2673 καταργέω

Force. When the complete or perfect thing (to teleion, G5046, a noun form, neuter singular) comes, the partial thing (to ek merous) will be abolished (katargethesetai, future passive of katargeo, G2673). The referent of the neuter noun-form the complete or perfect (to teleion) is the word-level crux of the question. Across 19 New Testament occurrences the word complete or perfect (teleios) ranges over mature persons (1 Corinthians 14:20; Ephesians 4:13; Hebrews 5:14), morally or relationally complete states (James 1:4; 1:25), and finished or whole things (Hebrews 9:11). The temporal clause meaning whenever it comes (hotan elthe) does not specify whether the coming is the completion of revelation, corporate maturity, or the end-of-age face-to-face of verse 12. The base word alone does not fix the date, which is why the cessation timing is contested.

1Cor.13.12 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0737 ἄρτι, G5119 τότε, G4383 πρόσωπον, G1108 γνώσις

Force. The immediate gloss on the complete or perfect (to teleion). Now (arti, G0737) we see through a mirror in a riddle (di esoptrou en ainigmati), but then (tote, G5119) face to face (prosopon pros prosopon, G4383, face to face); now (arti) I know in part (ek merous), then (tote) I will know fully even as I have been fully known. The pair now (arti) and then (tote) pair the present partiality of verse 9 with a future state characterized by direct, unmediated sight and exhaustive mutual knowledge. The phrase face to face (prosopon pros prosopon) is an Old Testament idiom for direct divine encounter, and the perfect passive form (a completed action whose result still stands, in passive voice) of the verb to know fully (epegnosthen, I have been fully known) describes an exhaustive knowing that is most naturally read as belonging to the end of the age rather than to the closing of the Bible. This verse is the strongest single word-level reason the cessation timing is disputed rather than settled in favor of an apostolic-age end-point.

Eph.2.20 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G2310 θεμέλιος, G4396 προφήτης

Force. The household of God is built (built upon, epoikodomethentes, aorist passive participle, that is, a completed past action in passive voice meaning having been built upon) upon the foundation (themelios, G2310, foundation) of the apostles and prophets, with Christ as the cornerstone (akrogoniaios, cornerstone). The foundation metaphor at the word level situates apostles and prophets at the structurally non-repeating base of the building, which supports an inference that the foundation-laying office is laid once and not relaid. The aorist participle (a participle expressing completed past action) marks a completed founding event. The metaphor speaks to office function and contains no explicit verb of cessation for spiritual gifts (charismata) generally; it bears on the apostolic office and the foundational prophetic role, not on tongues or healings as such.

Heb.1.1 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2980 λαλέω, G4396 προφήτης

Force. God spoke of old (palai, of old) in the prophets in many parts and many ways (polymeros kai polytropos, in many parts and many ways), then in these last days (ep eschatou ton hemeron, in these last days) in a Son. The temporal adverbs contrast a prior prophetic mode of speech with a definitive Son-mediated speech, which supports a redemptive-historical reading (reading the Bible as the unfolding story of God's saving acts in history) that the prophetic mode reached its end-point in the Son. The verse at the word level concerns the mode of divine revelation in the prophetic office, not the cessation of congregational spiritual gifts (charismata) as such, and the phrase in these last days (ep eschatou ton hemeron) names the present church age as the last days rather than a closed past.

Heb.2.4 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4592 σημείον, G5059 τέρας, G1411 δύναμις

Force. God co-witnessed (co-witnessed, synepimartyrountos, present participle of joint-attestation, that is, a verb form meaning bearing witness alongside) the proclaimed salvation by signs (semeiois, signs), wonders (teras, wonders), and various miracles (poikilais dynamesin, various miracles or powers). The participle is governed by the aorist verb (a completed past action) meaning it was confirmed (ebebaiotē, in Hebrews 2:3, the salvation having been confirmed) describing a past confirming act by those who heard the Lord. The grammar casts the sign cluster in a confirmatory function attached to the original proclamation, which supports a confirmatory reading. The verse states no explicit end-point or perpetuity for the signs themselves; the temporal force comes from the verb meaning it was confirmed (ebebaiotē) pairing the signs with the once-confirmed message.

2Cor.12.12 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4592 σημείον, G0652 απόστολος, G5059 τέρας, G1411 δύναμις

Force. The signs of the apostle were worked out among you (ta men semeia tou apostolou kateirgasthe en hymin): the signs of the apostle were worked out among you in all endurance, in signs and wonders and powers (signs, wonders, and powers, semeiois te kai terasin kai dynamesin). The grammatical form of the apostle (tou apostolou, G0652, a noun form indicating possession or association) is most naturally read as defining or appositional (that is, naming the same thing in another way), attaching the same sign cluster (signs, semeia; wonders, terata; miracles or powers, dynameis) to the marker of apostolic identity. The grammar gives a category label, the signs of the apostle, that at the word level ties the cluster to the apostolic office. It does not by itself say the signs cannot appear elsewhere, but it does anchor the cluster to a defining function of apostleship.

1Cor.12.7 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1411 δύναμις, G4394 προφητεία, G1100 γλώσσα

Force. The manifestation (phanerosis, a public showing) of the Spirit is given to each one (hekasto, to each one) for the common good, and the catalog in verses 8-11 lists miracles or workings of powers (energemata dynameon, workings of miracles or powers), prophecy, kinds of tongues, and interpretation as present operations apportioned by the one Spirit as he wills (kathos bouletai, as he wills). The present-tense (ongoing simple statement of fact) distribution language describes the gifts as operative in the Corinthian congregation without any temporal limiting clause. The catalog at the word level complicates a hard cessation-at-canon reading because it embeds no expiry.

1Cor.14.31 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4396 προφήτης, G4394 προφητεία

Force. You can all prophesy (dynasthe gar pantes propheteuein): you can all prophesy, one by one, so that all may learn and all be exhorted. The regulatory instructions across 1 Corinthians 14:26-33 treat prophecy, tongues, and interpretation as ongoing congregational practices to be ordered, not phased out, and contain no clause assigning them an expiry. The present-tense (ongoing simple statement of fact) imperatives at the word level complicate a reading that the gifts are intrinsically apostolic-only.

1Thess.5.20 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4394 προφητεία

Force. Do not despise prophecies, but test everything (propheteias me exoutheneite, alla panta dokimazete). Do not despise prophecies, but test all things and hold the good. The negative command both legitimizes prophecy as ongoing and subordinates it to evaluation, presenting prophecy as a function that can be wrong yet is valued in the congregation. The word-level force neither perpetuates nor terminates the gift on a fixed date.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
1Cor.13.10	1Cor.13.12	tsk	1
1Cor.13.9	1Cor.13.12	tsk	1
Eph.2.20	Eph.4.11	tsk	1
Eph.2.20	Isa.28.16	tsk	1
1Cor.14.32	1Cor.14.29	tsk	1
1Cor.14.31	1Cor.14.3	tsk	1
Heb.2.3	Heb.5.9	tsk	1

Complicating texts

1Cor.13.12 · addressed

Treated as a primary scripture entry rather than only a cross-reference because it glosses, at the word level, the complete or perfect (to teleion). The pair now (arti) versus then (tote), the face to face (prosopon pros prosopon) idiom for direct divine encounter, and the perfect passive form (a completed action whose result still stands, in passive voice) of the verb to know fully (epegnosthen) for exhaustive knowing read most naturally as the immediacy of the end of the age, which weighs against a canon-completion referent for the complete or perfect (to teleion) and is the strongest single word-level reason the cessation timing is disputed rather than settled in favor of an apostolic-age end-point. Recorded as a genuine countervailing datum without forcing it to resolve in either direction.

1Cor.12.7 · addressed

The present-tense (ongoing simple statement of fact) apportionment of miracles, prophecy, and tongues as he wills (kathos bouletai) is addressed as a word-level complication. The catalog shows the gifts operative in the congregation without an embedded expiry clause, so any cessation end-point must be argued from the complete or perfect (to teleion) at 1 Corinthians 13:10, or from the foundation (themelios) metaphor at Ephesians 2:20, or from the signs of the apostle (ta semeia tou apostolou) phrasing at 2 Corinthians 12:12, not from the gift list itself.

1Cor.14.31 · addressed

The regulatory commands for ongoing prophecy and tongues are addressed by noting that they govern present practice and assign no end-point; they neither establish perpetuity nor preclude a later cessation, so they are recorded as complicating but not decisive against a foundational reading.

1Thess.5.20 · addressed

The phrase do not despise (me exoutheneite) plus test all things (panta dokimazete) is addressed as presenting prophecy as a valued-but-testable ongoing function; the command carries no temporal limit, so it complicates a hard cessation reading without refuting a foundational one.

Acts.2.17 · addressed

Peter's Pentecost citation of Joel runs in the last days (en tais eschatais hemeraiis, in the last days), naming the church age as the last days during which God pours out his Spirit so that sons and daughters prophesy. The word-level force of the phrase of the last days (hemeron eschaton, a from-X grammatical form referring to days that are last) is to extend the prophetic outpouring across the whole period inaugurated at Pentecost. This complicates a strict apostolic-age end-point but does not by itself date the cessation of any particular gift; it is addressed by recording it as a real countervailing time-marker.

Concordance traversed

G2673, G3973, G5046, G3313, G4394, G4396, G1100, G1108, G2310, G4592, G5059, G1411, G0652, G0737, G5119, G4383

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

1Cor.13.8/pesei-piptei-katargethesetai at 1Cor.13.8: impact none. Some witnesses read it falls out (ekpiptei) or it falls (piptei, falls) for the it never fails (oudepote piptei) clause governing the love (he agape), and for the knowledge clause some apparatuses (collections of textual variants) mark a fall verb alongside it will be abolished (katargethesetai). The apparatus marks the falling form (piptei) in the bundle. The substitution swaps one fall or abolish verb for another and does not change the disputed status of the cessation timing or the referent of the complete or perfect (to teleion).

1Cor.13.10/to-tote at 1Cor.13.10: impact none. Minor article (the word the) and word-order marks at the partial thing (to ek merous) do not alter the word-level crux, which is the unspecified referent of the complete or perfect (to teleion), so the verdict is robust across the cited readings.

The Pauline corpus (the letters of Paul) is outside the published scope of the critical edition of New Testament textual variants (the ECM, Editio Critica Maior) for version 1; treated as ecm-shadow (running under the shadow of the critical edition though not yet covered by its published volumes). The cited variant units do not bear on the disputed verdict.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. cessationism, continuationism, open-but-cautious

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

cessationism: affirms · Reads the complete or perfect (to teleion, G5046) at 1 Corinthians 13:10 as the completion of the deposit of revelation (the body of God-given truth); reads the foundation metaphor of Ephesians 2:20 (foundation, themelios; cornerstone, akrogoniaios; the aorist participle meaning having been built upon, epoikodomethentes, that is, a completed past action in passive voice) as a non-repeating foundational office held by the apostles and the foundational prophets; reads Hebrews 1:1-2 as a redemptive-historical (history-of-salvation) transition from prophetic to Son-mediated speech; reads Hebrews 2:3-4 as casting sign and wonder vocabulary in the past-confirming participial frame (God co-witnessing, synepimartyroutos, under the verb meaning it was confirmed, ebebaiothe); and reads 2 Corinthians 12:12 the signs of the apostle (ta semeia tou apostolou) as a defining or appositional phrase tying the sign cluster to apostolic identity. The cumulative inference is that the attesting and foundational gifts lapsed once the message was confirmed and the apostolic office passed.

continuationism: denies · Reads the complete or perfect (to teleion) as the end-of-age state, anchored by 1 Corinthians 13:12 (now versus then, arti vs tote; face to face, prosopon pros prosopon; the perfect passive form meaning a completed action whose result still stands in passive voice, the verb to know fully, epegnosthen) where the contrast is now-partial seeing versus then-direct exhaustive knowing. Presses the present-tense (ongoing simple statement of fact) gift apportionment of 1 Corinthians 12:7-11 (as he wills, kathos bouletai) and the ongoing regulatory commands of 1 Corinthians 14:26-33 and 1 Thessalonians 5:19-21, none of which embed an expiry. Reads Acts 2:17 in the last days (en tais eschatais hemerais) as naming the entire church age as the period of Spirit-given prophesying, so the gifts persist until the second coming (the parousia, the return of Christ). Notes that no New Testament text gives an explicit date or verb of cessation for the sign gifts.

open-but-cautious: disputed · Holds that the word-level data underdetermines (does not fully fix) the referent of the complete or perfect (to teleion) at 1 Corinthians 13:10 and the force of the voice contrast between they will cease (pausontai, middle voice, the subject acts on its own) and they will be abolished (katargethesontai, passive voice, the action is done to them), so neither a hard cessation tied to the apostolic age nor an unqualified continuation can be established from the words alone. Notes that the foundational and confirmatory vocabulary at the word level anchors a structural argument while the present-tense (ongoing simple statement of fact) catalog and regulatory commands at the word level anchor an experiential argument, and the canon supplies both patterns without ranking them.

The verdict turns substantially on the unspecified referent of the complete or perfect (to teleion) at 1 Corinthians 13:10 and on whether the foundation, confirmation, and apostolic-sign language entails an end-point for the gifts. The progressive-revelation framing (the idea that God revealed truth in stages, Hebrews 1:1-2) bears on the cessation argument, hence comparing scripture with scripture (analogia_scripturae) and progressive_revelation are marked true, but the primary method remains grammatico-historical (reading according to grammar and historical setting) because the crux is at the level of words and grammar (the open referent of one neuter noun-form and the absence of an explicit cessation date).

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Whether the miraculous sign gifts (the apostolic office, prophecy, tongues, miraculous healings) continued beyond the apostolic age, or instead ceased with the apostolic age and the closing of the canon (the closing of the list of inspired books).

The stem asserts the cessation outcome and pairs it with a specific end-point (apostolic age and canon closing), which preloads the disputed referent of the complete or perfect (to teleion) and a framework conclusion. The neutralized form poses continuation versus cessation as an open question on equal word-level footing. The verdict is still derived on the original stem and returned as disputed because the word-level data sustains more than one defensible reading.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.13.8
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.13.10

morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.13.12
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Eph.2.20
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Heb.2.4
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	2Cor.12.12
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5046
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2673
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3973
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0652
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4383
syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	1Cor.13.10
syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	1Cor.13.12
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	1Cor.13.10
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Eph.2.20
interlinear	SBLGNT-text	SBLGNT-EULA	no	1Cor.13.8

License audit

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Reason. Citations include MACULA-Greek (CC-BY-NC-4.0, non-commercial, redistribute false) for the grammatical anchoring of the complete or perfect (to teleion) at 1 Corinthians 13:10 and the now (arti) / then (tote) / face (prosopon) construction at 1 Corinthians 13:12, and SBLGNT-text (SBLGNT-EULA, redistribute false) for the base Greek text. Either source alone makes the bundle non-redistributable for bulk publication.

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Flags

lexically-disputed · ecm-shadow